E BIDDING



↘ CHHATTISGARH
The ruling Congress promises hike in paddy MSP to Rs 3,000 per quintal from existing Rs 2,640–already Rs 600 above the central MSP. The BJP manifesto lists it at Rs 3,100. The Congress revises it to Rs 3,200. The state is the third largest contributor to central paddy stocks, after Punjab and Haryana

↘ TELANGANA
To overshadow the BRS regime's flagship Rythu Bandhu scheme that provides Rs 10,000 per acre to farmers across two seasons each year, Congress guarantees Rs 15,000 under Rythu Bharosa. BRS in turn promises a hike to Rs 16,000, though without including tenancy farmers like Congress

↘ RAJASTHAN
Ashok Gehlot brings a first-of-its-kind 'Agriculture Budget', providing 2,000 units of free power, waiving all crop loans from cooperative banks worth Rs 15,000 crore, benefiting around 22 lakh households

↘ MADHYA PRADESH
CM Shivraj Chouhan's 15-year reign has seen an expansion in irrigation–canals now reach 3.3 million hectares, four times more than in 2009-10. But at only Rs 7,919 per month, farm incomes are among the lowest in India. So Congress promises a minimum monthly income, besides other goodies

monthly income of farming households in MP is among the lowest in India. At Rs 7,919, it's about Rs 1,200 less than Rajasthan's and Rs 600 below Chhattisgarh's. It's on this hard ground—the farmer's lived reality—that non-BJP parties base their policies, rather more unabashedly leaning towards putting more remuneration in the hands of the tiller. This is where former CM Kamal Nath's promise of a minimum monthly income to farmers fits in. Farm debt waivers, free fertiliser/power/water, a Chhattisgarh-like bonus on MSP for wheat and paddy, state insurance to compensate for crop losses...it's all on the anvil.

In Rajasthan, CM Ashok Gehlot made grand gestures of his own, bringing a first-of-its-kind 'Agriculture Budget' last year, providing 2,000 units of free electricity to all farmers and waiving all crop loans from cooperative banks worth Rs 15,000 crore, benefiting around 2.2 million farming households. For the Congress, the showpiece is Chhattisgarh, where Baghel brought in the Rajiv Gandhi Kisan Nyay Yojna,

THE SEASON OF SOPS MAY NOT SOLVE THE DEEPER ISSUES: FARM DEBT, FOR ONE, OR THE LACK OF A CUSHION FOR PRICE CRASH CYCLES

under which the government paid input subsidy of Rs 21,912 crore to around 2.3 million kharif paddy farmers. Its Godhan Nyay Yojana (cow dung procurement scheme), under which it paid Rs 580 crore to cattle-owners, married welfare with woolly identity politics.

Spread the Rythu

Telangana CM K. Chandrasekhar Rao (KCR) has always positioned himself as a guardian angel of farmers. His showpiece is the Rythu Bandhu Scheme, incidentally the prototype for the Centre's PM-KISAN. From FY20, the state's investment support to landowning farmers was raised from Rs 4,000 to Rs 5,000 per acre per crop season. It's a success on the ground. From FY15 to FY23, it quadrupled rice output from 4.4 mt to 17.5 mt, engineering a near six-fold jump in paddy procurement from 2.4 mt to 14 mt. That's why, rather than walking back from the policy, each party is pushing the envelope. The Congress now promises Rs 15,000 to all farmers, including tenancy farmers. Eyeing a revival in its former stronghold, it also carried over an element from its Chhattisgarh formula, promising Rs 12,000 per year for farm labourers and a Rs 500 bonus above MSP for paddy. KCR then upped his Rythu Bandhu ante to Rs 16,000 (without mentioning tenants). Even the BJP has pledged Rs 10,000.

On another track, at a Mahabubnagar rally in September, Prime Minister Narendra Modi committed to the formation of a National Turmeric Board (NTB). A week later, that materialised. Turmeric is a sensitive issue in Telangana: this year, it lost its top rank to Maharashtra, which has nearly quintupled its area under cultivation since FY19. An MSP is now likely on this spice. Such context-specific policy reminds us that there's life beyond paddy and wheat—and beyond politics. Soyabean is selling at Rs 4,500 per quintal, compared to Rs 6,000 two years back (and below even the Rs 4,600 MSP), because of a surge in vegetable oil imports after duty cuts. Rajasthan's cotton belt is plagued by the pink bollworm. Tomato and onion go through seasonal traumas. Ethanol hovers like a future question mark. The present, though, is posed by farm debt and state insolvency. With liabilities running to 36.6 per cent of GSDP, even a Gehlot doesn't have the fiscal buffer to write off farm loans taken from public sector banks. Don't expect all that to be solved amid election cacophony. ■